Alexa Grunwaldt

Address: Department of Economics
Yale University
New Haven, CT 06520-8268

Telephone: +1 (414) 522-4529

E-mail: alexa.grunwaldt@yale.edu

Web page: alexagrunwaldt.github.io

Fields of Concentration:

Primary Fields: Labor Economics, Public Economics
Secondary Field: Development Economics

Qualifying Examinations Completed:

Oral: Labor Economics (2023), Public Economics (2023)

Dissertation Title: *Essays on Household Shocks, Incentives, and Economic Behavior*

Committee:

Professor Cormac O'Dea, Co-Chair
Professor Orazio Attanasio, Co-Chair
Professor Costas Meghir

Education:

Ph.D., Economics, Yale University, 2027 (expected)
M.Phil., Economics, Yale University, 2023
M.A., Economics, Yale University, 2022
B.A. (with Honors), Economics & German, University of Wisconsin, 2018

Fellowships, Honors and Awards:

University Fellowship, Yale University, 2021–2027
Cowles Foundation and Economic Growth Center Fellowship, Yale University, 2021–2026
Deutscher Akademischer Austauschdienst (DAAD) Graduate Studies Scholarship (2018, 2020)
Phi Beta Kappa (top 2% of class), University of Wisconsin—Madison (2018)
Kaden Foundation award for writing in the major, University of Wisconsin—Madison (2018)

Teaching Experience:

Spring 2024, Teaching Assistant to Prof. Cormac O'Dea, Introductory Microeconomics (Undergraduate), Yale College
Fall 2024-2026, Teaching Assistant to Prof. Ben Polak, Game Theory (Undergraduate & Graduate), Yale College
Spring 2025, Teaching Assistant to Prof. William Hawkins, Labor Economics (Undergraduate), Yale College

Research Experience:

Predoctoral Fellow to Prof. Bruce Meyer, University of Chicago (Washington, DC and Chicago, IL), 2018-2020
Research Assistant to Prof. Orazio Attanasio, Yale University, 2023-2024

Working Papers:

"The Economic Consequences of Alzheimer's and Dementia: Evidence from Patients and Households in Colombia" with Christian Posso and Andrea Franco Hernandez (October 2026), *Job Market Paper*

"State Income Taxes and Retiree Migration: Evidence from Household-Specific Tax Incentives" (October 2026)

"Household Criminality and the Intergenerational Transmission of Disadvantage: Evidence from Medellín, Colombia" with Christian Posso (October 2026)

"Homelessness and the Persistence of Deprivation: Income, Employment, and Safety Net Participation" with Bruce D. Meyer, Angela Wyse, Gillian Meyer, and Derek Wu (April 2024), *NBER Working Paper 32323*

Languages:

English (native), German (fluent)

References:

Prof. Cormac O'Dea
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
PO Box
Phone: 203-432-7572
cormac.odea@yale.edu

Prof. Orazio Attanasio
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
PO Box
Phone: 203-432-3569
orazio.attanasio@yale.edu

Prof. Costas Meghir
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
PO Box
Phone: 203-432-2558
c.meghir@yale.edu

Prof. Benjamin Polak (Teaching reference)
Yale University
Department of Economics
New Haven, CT 06520
PO Box
Phone: 203-432-3560
benjamin.polak@yale.edu

Dissertation Abstract

My dissertation uses rich survey and administrative microdata to study how individuals and households respond to changes in their policy, household, and health environments. Across three essays, I examine residential decisions at retirement, children's outcomes following changes in household composition, and the economic consequences of Alzheimer's disease and related dementias for patients and their families.

The Economic Consequences of Alzheimer's and Dementia: Evidence from Patients and Households in Colombia with Christian Posso and Andrea Franco Hernandez, [Job Market Paper]

Alzheimer's disease and related dementias (ADRD) can reduce a patient's ability to work while increasing the need for help at home. Relatives may work more to replace lost income, or reduce work as care needs and other household responsibilities grow. This paper studies how formal employment and earnings change for both patients and their household members in Colombia. The setting is particularly informative because formal long-term care is limited, multigenerational living is common, and informal employment offers a possible alternative to formal jobs.

We link national administrative health records to monthly formal-employment and earnings data and SISBEN household rosters. We first describe patients' health-care use around their first recorded ADRD diagnosis. We then examine labor-market outcomes in two complementary samples: working-age patients with strong formal employment before diagnosis and working-age members of households containing a diagnosed patient. For each diagnosis period, we match newly diagnosed patients or affected households to observationally similar, never-diagnosed comparison units eligible at the same time. Stacked difference-in-differences event studies trace changes before and after diagnosis relative to those contemporaneous comparisons.

Health-care use rises around the first recorded diagnosis. Among working-age patients, formal employment is approximately 15 percentage points lower two years later relative to matched comparisons, and quarterly formal earnings decline among both women and men. In the household sample, the share of other working-age members formally employed is about 3.5 percentage points lower after one year and 4.5 points lower after two. Formal employment and earnings decline among both female and male members, providing no evidence that relatives compensate for the patient's losses by increasing their own formal work. These results extend evidence on dementia's economic burden to household members in a middle-income setting and document losses in formal-sector attachment that patient-level analyses miss. Because we do not observe informal earnings or caregiving time, we cannot determine whether relatives stop working altogether or who provides care. Symptoms and economic adjustment may also precede diagnosis, so we interpret the estimates as deterioration surrounding a first recorded diagnosis rather than the effect of disease onset.

State Income Taxes and Retiree Migration: Evidence from Household-Specific Tax Incentives

States compete to attract retirees through tax preferences for Social Security, pensions, and other retirement income. Whether these policies induce retirees to leave their current state—or instead shape where those already planning to move settle—is less clear. This paper examines both decisions.

Measuring the relevant tax incentive requires calculating how each household's particular mix of income would be taxed in every potential destination, rather than comparing statutory tax rates alone.

I use data from the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement from 1982–2019, which contain detailed information on household income sources, household composition, and state of residence in both the current and previous year. I combine these data with TAXSIM to calculate the after-tax income each retiree household would receive in every potential destination state based on its observed income profile. I then estimate a conditional logit model in which retiree households choose among all fifty states, including the option of remaining in their origin state. By separately examining the full retiree population, those who have moved within the last year, and interstate movers within the last year, I distinguish the role of taxes in the decision to leave the origin state from their role in destination choice conditional on moving.

I find little evidence that differences in after-tax income substantially affect location choices for the broader population of retirees aged 65–66. Inverse distance from the origin is a much stronger predictor of location choice, consistent with substantial moving costs and attachment to place. Among recent movers, estimated responses to after-tax income are larger for higher-income households in some specifications, although these estimates are imprecise. The clearest evidence of tax responsiveness emerges among interstate movers: conditional on moving across state lines, retirees are significantly more likely to choose destinations in which they would receive higher after-tax income. These results suggest that state tax policy does little to induce otherwise stationary retirees to relocate, but can affect competition across states for retirees who have already decided to make an interstate move.

Household Criminality and the Intergenerational Transmission of Disadvantage: Evidence from Medellín, Colombia with Christian Posso

This paper examines how children's educational and criminal outcomes change when an adult who engages in criminal activity enters their household. Using linked household survey, education, and crime records from Medellín, Colombia, we compare children who experience the arrival of an adult who commits a crime with children who experience the arrival of an adult who does not. By comparing households that all experience an adult move-in, we isolate differences associated with the subsequent criminal involvement of the entering adult.

Children exposed to a criminally involved adult mover are approximately 9–10 percentage points more likely to drop out of school and 1–1.3 percentage points more likely to have a recorded criminal offense. Among students observed taking the high-school mathematics exam, scores are roughly 0.05–0.06 standard deviations lower. These estimates remain similar after matching children on observed child, household, and mover characteristics. The results show that the arrival of an adult who becomes involved in crime is associated with meaningful deterioration in both educational attainment and children's own involvement with the criminal justice system.